

History of the Liberation War of Bangladesh

1) Different Types of Discrimination Between East and West Pakistan

During the period when Bangladesh was East Pakistan, the people of the eastern wing faced systematic discrimination by the ruling elite of West Pakistan. These inequalities were economic, political, cultural, and social.

➤ **Economic Discrimination**

- East Pakistan's economy was exploited to benefit West Pakistan.
- Despite having more than half of the total population, the economic investment, industry, and resources were heavily biased toward West Pakistan.
- East Pakistan earned valuable foreign exchange through jute and other exports, but reinvestment in the region remained minimal. This caused huge economic inequality between the two wings.

➤ **Political Discrimination**

- Bengalis were not given fair political power despite winning a majority in the 1970 General Election.
- Sheikh Mujibur Rahman's party (Awami League) won most seats in the National Assembly, but the government never transferred power.
- As a result, Bengalis felt denied of their democratic rights and political representation.

➤ **Cultural and Language Discrimination**

- The central government of Pakistan tried to impose Urdu as the sole national language, ignoring Bengali — the language of the majority in East Pakistan.
- This sparked the Language Movement, and laid the foundation for later national demands.

Language suppression was a major cultural injustice.

➤ **Military and Institutional Inequality**

- Senior positions in the army, government services, and bureaucracy were dominated by West Pakistanis.
- East Pakistanis were under-represented in key posts despite being the majority of the population. This led to poor decision-making for East Pakistani interests and widened grievances.

2) Role of Foreign Countries in the Liberation War of Bangladesh

The Bangladesh Liberation War (1971) did not happen in isolation — several foreign countries acted in ways that shaped the war's course and outcome.

1. India

- India played the most significant role in supporting Bangladesh's independence struggle.
- It provided shelter to over a million refugees fleeing Pakistani repression.
- India trained the Mukti Bahini (freedom fighters) and supplied weapons throughout the nine-month conflict.
- Indian military intervention in December 1971 helped defeat the Pakistan Army and hastened victory.
- India officially recognized Bangladesh as an independent nation on 6 December 1971.
- India's support was both humanitarian and strategic.

2. Soviet Union

- The Soviet Union backed India and Bangladesh diplomatically and politically.
- In the United Nations Security Council (UNSC), the Soviets used their veto power to block ceasefire resolutions that would have favored Pakistan.
- Soviet support helped legitimize the Bangladesh cause on the world stage and protected it from diplomatic isolation.
- Their support was crucial for international backing.

3. China

- China supported Pakistan politically and diplomatically due to their strategic alliance.
- China opposed international interference and described the conflict as Pakistan's "internal matter," attempting to limit global pressure against Pakistan.
- China's role was largely in defense of its Cold War ally.

4. United States

- The U.S. government did not support Bangladesh's independence openly, as it wanted to maintain good relations with Pakistan.

- The U.S. provided financial and logistical aid to Pakistan and proposed a ceasefire that would have prevented Pakistan's defeat.
- The U.S. even sent the 7th Fleet to the Indian Ocean as a show of support for Pakistan, although it never engaged in action.
- The U.S. also offered some humanitarian financial aid to India for refugee support without recognizing the independence movement.
- The U.S. was cautious and aligned with Pakistan for strategic reasons.

ICT INDUSTRY

1. History of the ICT Industry in Bangladesh

- **First Computer:** Bangladesh has about six decades of experience in using computers. In its early days, the ICT sector in Bangladesh was mainly focused on hardware operations. The first 'second generation' mainframe computer was installed in 1964 at Dhaka University. Soon after this, several banks and industrial concerns started using computers, mainly for accounting.
- **First Computer Center:** In 1982, a computer center was established at the Bangladesh University of Engineering and Technology. This center, later renamed the Department of Computer Science and Engineering, has played a pivotal role in Bangladeshi IT education since its inception.
- **The Innovation of Bangla Writing:** The innovation of software concerning "Bangla writing" on computers materialized in 1987. Mainul Islam managed to write Bangla on an Apple Macintosh computer. With the ability to use Bangla on computers, the value of computers in offices quickly rose.
- **Introduction of the Internet:** After the introduction of the internet in 1996, the development of exportable software and multimedia systems commenced.
- **Journey of BCS:** The Bangladesh Computer Society (BCS), an association of the IT professionals, for instance, was formed in 1979. BCC, the Bangladesh Computer Council, is the consequence of the evolution of the National Computer Committee constituted in 1983.
- **Journey of many Organizations:** In 1997 It is recognized that the ICT industry is a potential sector and it has an impact on the economy. After that in collaboration with industry associations (BCS, BCC, BASIS, and BACCO) and international trade support institutions the government has taken both short and long term measures to support and enhance the development of the domestic sector and increase the export of ICT products. BASIS, established in 1997, promotes the ICT sector through awareness building, practical education for new graduates and paid internships, and training programs for mid-career employees.
- **Connected with Submarine Cable:** Bangladesh got connected with its first undersea cable, SEA-ME-WE 4, in 2006. Development of ICT Sector-2
- **Software Park:** Software Technology Park (STP) at Janata Tower was established in Dhaka in 2015.

- **High Tech Park:** Bangladesh Hi-tech Park Authority is a government agency in Bangladesh dedicated to establish, manage and operate technology business parks throughout the country. Formed in 2010, BHTPA is now implementing the projects including the Kaliakoir Hi-Tech Park in Gazipur District and Jessore Software Technology Park. Planned projects include Mohakhali IT Village in Dhaka, Barendra Silicon City in Paba Upazila of Rajshahi District, and Sylhet Electronic City in Companiganj Upazila, Sylhet. BHTPA is also approving private hi-tech park to implemented by private companies. Thus far, 39 hi-tech parks have been under constructions and approved for construction by BHTPA in different regions in Bangladesh.
- **A2I Project:** Aspire to Innovate (a2i) of the ICT Division supported by UNDP, a special program of the government's Digital Bangladesh agenda, is a key driver of the nation's goal of becoming a developed country by 2041 and in achieving the 2030 Sustainable Development Goals.

2. Key Objectives of the National ICT Policy 2018

National ICT Policy – 2018 (8 Objectives & 55 Themes)

The Bangladesh government's National ICT Policy 2018 aims to transform the country into a knowledge-based society by using technology to achieve national development goals, including aspects of Vision 2021, Vision 2041, and the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

Digital Government (6 Themes)

This objective focuses on leveraging ICT to establish a transparent, responsive, and accountable government. This involves the digitalization of all government services, internal operations, and the implementation of interoperable e-government platforms to provide services efficiently and affordably to citizens, including those in rural areas.

Digital Security (9 Themes)

A critical goal is to create a secure and inclusive digital ecosystem by safeguarding individuals, organizations, and national assets from various cyber threats like hacking, data breaches, and cyber-terrorism. The policy led to the enactment of the Digital Security Act 2018 and the establishment of institutions like the national

Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT) to monitor and respond to cyber threats effectively.

Social Equity, Universal Access (8 Themes)

This objective strives to ensure that the benefits of the digital revolution are accessible to all citizens, including persons with disabilities and those in remote areas, thereby promoting social equity and equal opportunity. This involves strengthening local-level ICT infrastructure and promoting rural connectivity and development.

Education, Research, Innovation (9 Themes)

The policy promotes the integration of ICT into education at all levels (primary, secondary, and tertiary) to improve quality and ensure that all universities provide global standard ICT education. It also encourages research and development (R&D) in emerging technologies like AI, blockchain, robotics, and biotech through tech parks and incubators.

Skill Development, Employment Generation (5 Themes)

A primary focus is on developing a large pool of world-class ICT professionals to meet the demands of both local and global markets. The policy aims to train a significant number of youth in IT and freelancing, increase the number of software engineers and cybersecurity professionals, and revamp the ICT curriculum in schools and universities.

Strengthening Domestic Capability (7 Themes)

This objective centers on reducing dependency on foreign technology by encouraging private investment, promoting the local software and hardware industries, and increasing local content. It encourages the establishment of production facilities for components and peripherals and promotes joint ventures between local and foreign entrepreneurs.

Environment, Climate & Disaster Management (5 Themes)

The policy aims to use ICT and GIS-based systems to address environmental challenges and manage disasters effectively. This includes collecting and disseminating information on environmental problems to create awareness and using IT systems for national-level planning and conservation.

Enhancing Productivity (6 Themes)

This objective focuses on promoting and facilitating the use of ICT in all sectors of the economy—including agriculture, health care, and transportation—to improve efficiency and boost overall productivity. It aims to simplify e-commerce regulations, promote digital payments, and create an enabling environment for startups and tech entrepreneurs.

3.Strengths and Weaknesses of the ICT Industry in Bangladesh

➤ Strength

- 1.One of the biggest strengths of the ICT sector is the young and educated workforce.
- ICT industry in Bangladesh is still relatively small. Looking at the characteristics of the market, and the growth of ICT services and products exported from Bangladesh over recent years we can conclude that the significance of the ICT sector for the Bangladeshi economy will grow in the near future.
- According to BASIS estimations within the next five years 5% of Bangladesh's total GDP will come from the software and IT services sector and over 1,50,000 Software and IT professionals will be working in the Bangladeshi IT industry by 2025.
- Export earnings from software and IT-related services of the last 12 months crossed the \$1 billion mark.
- It is internationally recognized that if the use of internet increases by 10%, the gross domestic product (GDP) of a country will go up by 1%.
- Bangabandhu Hi-Tech Park at Kaliakoir will create jobs for 1,00,000 people

➤ Weaknesses

- Infrastructure and power shortages.
- Lack of reliable infrastructure.
- Internet speed, bandwidth, and electricity
- Lack of focus and scale to take up large-scale long-term projects.

- Lack of soft skills in Bangladesh (If you have 100 candidates for the job, probably just 2 will have the right soft skills)
- Gap between what the industry needs and IT graduates.
- Lack of investment
- Political instability.

